

Infusing Entrepreneurial Mindset in Higher Education

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Editor's Note: Following is part one of a two-part series.

The goal of any higher education institution is to graduate students who are well rounded and generally prepared for the workforce. A college graduate should have skills in critical thinking, problem solving, effective communication, and teamwork.

According to the Network for Teaching Entrepreneurship, “An entrepreneurial mindset is a set of skills that enable people to identify and make the most of opportunities, overcome and learn from setbacks, and succeed in a variety of settings.” Put another way, the goal of higher education is to infuse the entrepreneurial mindset in students and graduates.

Simulated Workplaces

Implementing the entrepreneurial mindset in a college course can be achieved in several ways. In West Virginia, the K-12 Department of Education has created a program called “Simulated Workplace” (wvde.us/simulated-workplace), where classrooms are transformed into student-led businesses that follow real-world business practices, with students applying what they learn. This could easily be implemented in higher education classrooms.

In the simulated workplace approach, there are twelve protocols. They involve classes with student-led companies, which have an application/interview structure, a formal attendance and drug testing system, and commitment to the 6S lean manufacturing safety protocols.

These companies emphasize workplace teams and project-based learning, along with company meetings, onsite business reviews, and accountability. Students take the concepts of a class and apply them directly to this business. This is a great example of incorporating an entrepreneurial mindset into learning. In higher education, there's an opportunity to have a student cohort do the same thing over several courses throughout the degree, thereby expanding the learning experience.

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At West Virginia University at Parkersburg, college leaders are planning to create an entrepreneurial business incubator at its new campus. Twenty percent of the incubator seats will be reserved for student startups, with a large focus on high-tech. A major goal is to revitalize the local economy and create in-demand, high-paying jobs.

Tying the Academic Work to the Real World

Other examples include having students craft their own business ideas and use those as the basis for class projects or assigning students to teams that compete on assignments to create something for a business. Another approach might be dividing a marketing class into two teams, with each team producing marketing plans for a local business and competing against each other.

The business owner or manager could provide regular feedback and help select a winning plan for the company or organization. By tying academic work to the real world, these lessons become more relevant to students, helping them to engage in the lessons at hand while also giving back to the local community. Your school can also leverage this approach with your pitch competition winners and runners-up, helping them to flesh out their ideas and simultaneously spreading the academic opportunity to more of the campus.



The author, Charles Almond (standing), troubleshoots a networking problem with WVU-Parkersburg student Anthony Bowie.

While college students often think of class content as some abstract thing they are studying, entrepreneurs deal with real-world problems and real-world solutions. By adopting an entrepreneurial mindset throughout the curriculum, students can become more engaged, and coursework will become more immediately relevant to them. All of this can have the added benefit of improving retention and recruitment as well. In the process, students will gain the skills that make entrepreneurs successful, which is exactly what a college education should provide.

Regardless of the field any student may choose to enter upon graduation, ingraining the skills of an entrepreneurial mindset will ensure that students are equipped to handle any challenges that may come their way. ●



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